

Sermons on Joshua Chapter 1

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01. The Great Commission (1:1-9)

The first reading that we'll start with is from the book of Joshua, verses 1-9.

And it happened after the death of Moses the servant of Jehovah, Jehovah spoke to Joshua the son of Nun, Moses' minister, saying, My servant Moses is dead. And now rise up, cross over this Jordan, you and all this people, to the land which I am giving to them, to the sons of Israel. Every place on which the sole of your foot shall tread, I have given it to you, as I spoke to Moses. From the wilderness, and this Lebanon, even to the great river, the river Euphrates, all the land of the Hittites, and to the Great Sea toward the setting of the sun, shall be your border. No man shall be able to stand before you all the days of your life. As I was with Moses, so I will be with you. I will not fail you nor will I forsake you. Be strong and brave. For you shall cause this people to inherit the land which I swore to their fathers to give to them. Only be strong and very brave, so that you may take heed to do according to all the Law which Moses My servant commanded you. Do not turn from it to the right or to the left, that you may act wisely wherever you go. This book of the Law shall not depart out of your mouth, and you shall meditate on it by day and by night, so that you shall be on guard to do according to all that is written in it. For then you shall prosper your way, and then you shall act wisely. thing represented the Lord and the celestial and spiritual things of His kingdom. This applied not only to religious Have I not commanded you? Be strong and brave. Do not be afraid or discouraged, for Jehovah your God is with you in all places where you go.

And coming up Jesus talked with them, saying, All authority in Heaven and on earth was given to Me.
Then having gone, disciple all nations, baptizing them into the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit,
teaching them to observe all things, whatever I commanded you. And, behold, I am with you all the days until the completion of the age. Amen. (Matthew 28:18-20)

That 'the land of Canaan' represents the Lord's kingdom in heaven and on earth becomes clear from many things in the Word. The reason it does so is that the representative Church was established in that land, a Church in which every single thing represented the Lord and the celestial and spiritual things of His kingdom. This applied not only to religious observances but also to everything associated with those observances -- to both the persons who ministered and to the things they administered, and even to the places where the ministrations took place because the representative Church was centred there the land was consequently called 'the Holy Land', even though it was anything but holy, seeing that idolaters and profaners inhabited it.
(Arcana Coelestia 1437)

All the historicals of the Word, as well as its prophetic parts, contain a spiritual sense that treats, not of the sons of Israel and of nations and peoples, but of the church and its establishment and progress, for this is the spiritual of the Word, while the history is the natural that contains the spiritual ... "the land of Canaan," into which the sons of Israel were brought, signifies the church, and "Jordan" signifies the first entrance into it; and "the waters of Jordan" signify truths that introduce into it, which are such as those of the literal sense of the Word, for those are what first introduce.
(Apocalypse Explained 700)

We begin a new series today in which we look at the book of Joshua. This book deals with the conquest of Canaan by the Israelites, under Joshua as their leader. After the death of Moses, Joshua is appointed by Jehovah to lead the people of Israel to complete this task. We should note from the outset that the name *Joshua* and *Jesus* are the same. Je-ho-sua and Je-shua both mean "*Jehovah is Salvation*". Moses had led the sons of Israel out of Egypt from under the dominion of Pharaoh; he received the law from Jehovah and delivered this to the Israelites.

By and large we can view the Moses period of leadership as a period of instruction from the Word in spiritual matters. The leadership under Joshua marks a change of state where what has been learnt under Moses now needs to be applied to life. Spiritually, when we read of *death* in the Word it indicates a movement from one state to another. So death in the Word doesn't actually mean death, rather, it means new life or the coming into being of a new state of life as the old one passes away.

In the New Testament we can see a parallel of this change of state from Moses to Joshua in the life of the Lord in relation to His disciples. The Moses period can be seen in that period of the Lord's life when He was largely engaged in teaching or giving instruction to His disciples up to His death. The Joshua period for the disciples begins after His resurrection and this can be seen in the similarity between the commissioning of Joshua and what has come to be called the Great Commission given to the disciples.

Both are commands to go forth and conquer or bring all things under the rule and authority of what the Word teaches. Therefore, in this series that we are about to embark on, the Book of Joshua is to be viewed as holding the detail of what the Great Commission found in the New Testament actually involves. The Great Commission is first and foremost a call to the path of inner spiritual growth or

regeneration, through taking the instruction we have received in spiritual things and applying it to life. If we would do that then we would find that life would present us with opportunities to share with others the good things that the Lord has imparted into us in ways in which the deeper spiritual needs of people can be truly met.

In order to respond to the Great Commission to take the Gospel out to all nations effectively, we need to appreciate that the responsibility that falls on the greater Church, falls onto the personal individual level of the Church first, and that it is the quality of the work done by individuals who make up a spiritual community that governs the spiritual quality of that community's efforts to reach out and impact the lives of others around them for good.

This is a sobering thought; our personal individual effort to live from the Word is the most important contribution any one of us can make to the health and wellbeing of this collective spiritual community. Our effort to read the Word, to study the doctrines for Spiritual Christianity and apply them to life on a personal level sets the ground for being able to contribute in a powerful way to the health and wellbeing of the community as well as in the other communities we are in contact with in our wider spheres of influence.

So work on oneself is important because it's the means by which the Lord can be more fully present in our world. It's the means by which we can develop spiritual sensitivity to the spiritual needs of others. It is also the way in which real empathy and compassion for others is developed. It's the way by which possibilities are created to build bridges of trust over which genuine spiritual connections can be made. For it is through work on ourselves in response to the Word that we are able to support others in their spiritual growth and development, and it is in this ability to support one another that a true spiritual community or a collective expression of the church can come into being.

The land of Canaan represents the human mind or the ground out of which the affections and thoughts belonging to celestial and spiritual matters arise. This is why it corresponds to the Church, because the Church is nothing other than celestial and spiritual things, or goods and truths made manifest in human consciousness as good affections and true thoughts which motivate and enable a person to express themselves in loving actions. The goal of the spiritual life on a personal level is to become an individual church through having what is unloving and untrue removed from our life.

Joshua represents the transition from knowing to becoming, or from having an intellectual interest in spiritual matters to using this knowledge as a means of examining the quality of one's life. Moses and Joshua represent the Word at different stages of a person's spiritual life. There is a time for learning the stories of the Word and what the doctrines for Spiritual Christianity teach, and this is what is meant by Moses, but there comes a time when the Lord no longer speaks to us through Moses, when the approach represented by Moses dies and no longer can sustain us. At this point the emphasis shifts and the voice of Lord is heard through Joshua or the application of the Word to life.

Our spirituality must become practical. But by practical we don't mean a focus on the level of life found in the external or natural world. The practical application of spiritual truths has to do with their application to the inner world of the life of the mind. It is the life or quality of our affections and thoughts that form the practical dimension of spiritual work. And it is only by attending to this level of life that our external activities in the world can take on a spiritual quality. All external expressions of

love take their quality from the internal quality of the mind from which they come.

This is why Spiritual Christianity directs a person's attention to reflection on their inner mental life and activity. This in no way diminishes the need to attend to external matters, to act faithfully and justly in all that we do, however this is done in order to bring a degree of stability into the externals of life, so that the internal things can then be attended to while being fully engaged in the externals as well.

So we read ...

My servant Moses is dead. And now rise up, cross over this Jordan, you and all this people, to the land which I am giving to them, to the sons of Israel.

The Word that comes to us in the Joshua state brings us to a realisation that the ways of the past are no longer able to take us on into what lies ahead. Moses is dead. The time of external instruction is over, and a more internal state of application of the Word is being urged. This is seen in the instruction, "*And now rise up, cross over this Jordan ...* " To speak of *rising up* spiritually means to turn inwardly to what is deeper. At the same time Joshua is told to "*cross over*", a phrase that speaks of a transition, of a crossing over from one state to another, and that transition involves crossing over the Jordan River.

The river Jordan made up one of the boundaries of the land of Canaan. Now a boundary forms a border between what lies within and what lies without. And because Canaan corresponds to that part of the human mind specifically related to a person's understanding of spiritual things formed from goods and truths of the Word, the river Jordan must correspond to a stream of knowledge related to the Word itself. The river Jordan corresponds to the Word understood according to its literal meaning. And as the literal meaning of the Word forms a boundary, it is something that must be "*crossed over*" if we are to gain access to the spiritual meaning of the Word that is able to save us from our ego or proprium's dominance over the life of our affections and thoughts.

Now this *crossing over* or transition from a literal understanding of the Word to a spiritual understanding of it can only occur when we are willing to examine our internal life with a view to repentance — to working to have our thinking and feeling structures changed. This is what the phrase, "*And now rise up, cross over this Jordan ...* " means. It is the Word admonishing all people to look to the inner things of life, an invitation to go beyond the mere surface things of religion and begin to explore its depths in relation to what's going on within their own life.

The external things of religion have to do with buildings, sacraments, rites, rituals, priests or ministers, and services etc, but none of this forms the essence of true religion, they are merely representative elements that keep the idea of religion alive on the most external plane of life. The truly religious life is found in a person's willingness to acknowledge the Divine and to freely respond to their understanding of truth for no other reason than that it is the right thing to do, or the right way to live and be in life.

When this attitude is taken up then a person begins to view their affections and thoughts to discover their quality using the Word. Self examination by means of the Word is described by verse 3 where it

says that ...

Every place on which the sole of your foot shall tread, I have given it to you, as I spoke to Moses.

Joshua is the Word that saves us and the sole of its foot is the literal sense which contains the spiritual sense. When we take hold of the Word and look to the Lord to reveal those things that are opposed to the spiritual life in order to have them removed, even as we are doing as we look into the book of Joshua, then the literal sense or the lowest or most external aspect of the Word, which is here called, *"the sole of your foot"* or *"the sole of Jehovah Saviour's foot"*, is brought into contact with the states of our mind, which is the ground the Word treads upon. Thus by means of literal sense of the Word understood in the light of the principles of Spiritual Christianity, our states of mind are exposed to spiritual truths by which the mind can be reclaimed by the Lord from the dominance of self centred affections and false perspectives of the proprium.

This is the story of Joshua. It's the story of the regeneration of the human mind, a story of battles and of riding into the interior land of the mind where the things that oppose the life of heaven can be encountered. This is the Great Commission given to all those who would be the Lord's disciples. And for this work the Lord says ...

Have I not commanded you? Be strong and brave. Do not be afraid or discouraged, for Jehovah your God is with you in all places where you go.

02. Preparations For Entering The Land (1:10-18)

Then Joshua commanded the officers of the people, saying, Pass through the camp and command the people, saying, Prepare food for you. For within three days you are crossing this Jordan to go in to possess the land which Jehovah your God is giving to you, to possess it. And Joshua spoke to the Reubenites, and to the Gadites, and to the half tribe of Manasseh, saying, Remember the word which Moses the servant of Jehovah commanded you, saying, Jehovah your God has given you rest, and He has given to you this land. Your wives, your little ones, and your livestock shall remain in the land which Moses has given to you beyond the Jordan. But you shall cross over armed before your brothers, all the mighty warriors, and shall help them, until Jehovah has given rest to your brothers, as well as to you, and they, even they have possessed the land which Jehovah your God is giving to them. Then you may return to the land of your possession, and may possess it, which Moses the servant of Jehovah has given to you beyond the Jordan toward the rising of the sun. And they answered Joshua, saying, We will do all that you command us; and we will go everywhere you shall send us. According to all we heard from Moses, so we will listen to you. Surely Jehovah your God is with you, as He has been with Moses. Whoever rebels against your mouth, and will not listen to your commands in all that you say to him, he shall die. Only, be strong and brave. (Joshua 1:10-18)

But He said to them, I have food to eat which you do not know. Then the disciples said to one another, No one brought Him food to eat? Jesus said to them, My food is that I should do the will of Him who sent Me, and that I may finish His work. (John 4:32-34)

Joshua commanded, Pass through the middle of the camp, and command the people saying, Prepare provisions for yourselves, for within three days you will be crossing this Jordan to go and take possession of the land. 'The crossing of the Jordan' represented the introduction of the children of Israel, that is, of the regenerate, into the Lord's kingdom, 'Joshua', who led them in, representing the Lord Himself. (Arcana Coelestia 901)

In the internal sense 'food' means, strictly speaking, those things which nourish a person's soul, that is, which nourish him when his bodily life is ended. For when this is ended his soul or spirit is living, and he no longer needs material food as he did in the world; but he does need spiritual food, which consists in everything that has a useful purpose and everything leading to this. That which leads to what has a useful purpose is knowing what goodness and truth are; and that which has such a purpose is the desire to realize these in actions. These are the things with which angels are nourished and which are therefore called spiritual and celestial foods. A person's mind -- the place within him where his will and understanding, that is, his intentions or ends in view, reside -- is nourished by no other kind of food, even while he lives in the body. Material food does not extend as far as that; it extends only to his bodily parts, which are sustained by that material food to the end that the mind may be sustained by food for the mind while the body is sustained by food for the body, that is, to the end that there may be a healthy mind in a healthy body.
(Arcana Coelestia 5293)

Last time we spoke about what was spiritually represented by the change of leadership to Joshua following the death of Moses. We saw that this shift represents a shift in the state of mind of a person when they move from being led by an affection for knowledge in regard to the things of the Word, to being lead by an affection for applying its spiritual principles to their inner mental life, to their thought and feeling life. Joshua represents the understanding of the Word that arises when we look to bring it into connection with the inner activity of our minds through the work of self examination and reflection with a view to making changes in response to what is revealed.

This is an important point and should not be lost on us. The understanding of the Word that is represented by Joshua only comes into existence for us when we make a real effort to do inner spiritual work on ourselves. It's a basic spiritual law that we are given only what we need and what we need is governed by what we are prepared to do with what we already have. The Word and the doctrines for Spiritual Christianity are food, they are bread for our inner man and in order to benefit from the goodness that exists within them we have to take them into our life. This is done by reading and studying them with a view to having them govern the inner and outer dimensions of our life. They are food for the spiritual man because the spiritual man is our mind and the mind is built up through feeding on ideas and concepts that support its desires. Food of a nourishing spiritual quality is therefore ideas and concepts that support useful spiritual ends, which Spiritual Christianity identifies as love to the Lord and love to our neighbour.

So, living a spiritual life requires us to respond to the Word in order that spiritual food might be prepared for our inner life. So we read in verse 10-11 that ...

...Joshua commanded the officers of the people, saying, Pass through the camp and command the people, saying, Prepare food for you. For within three days you are crossing this Jordan to go in to possess the land which Jehovah your God is giving to you, to possess it.

This whole process which we are undertaking in seeing how the Scriptures can be understood so that they can be applied to a more internal approach to spiritual life is what it means to "*Prepare food*". Notice that this command to "*prepare food*" comes from Joshua and is given to "*the officers*" who in turn are to pass it on to "*the people*". Joshua, as we have seen, represents the Word and as such is that through which the Lord makes Himself known. How we understand the Word or interpret it depends on the spiritual teachings we hold to, or our doctrine. The term "*officers*" in this verse can also mean *scribes*, and this fits for it is our doctrine that determines how the Word is inscribed onto our understanding.

So by the Word stating that "*Joshua commanded the officers*" it teaches that the Word is understood according to the doctrine a person holds. If the spiritual teachings we hold to emphasizes an inner focus and application then this is how the Word will be understood. On the other hand if it is focussed more on the literal meaning then what will be seen as important will be things that have more to do with outer life. This is why so much of the Bible can mean different things to different people. Spiritual Christianity takes an inner focus in regard to its application of Biblical truths to life.

Some of those who take a more literal view of the book of Joshua, for example, hold to doctrines that use its contents as justification for the existence of a Jewish state in the world. Therefore they read its stories and interpret them in a way that supports this view. The doctrines for Spiritual Christianity teach that all things in the Word concern themselves solely with spiritual things and the literal text is merely a container which when spiritually understood, is seen to open up, in detail, the inner processes concerning the spiritual regeneration of the human mind.

So when we come to the book of Joshua and apply the principles of Spiritual Christianity, we find ourselves being instructed by the Word or Joshua to prepare food of a spiritual nature and quality so that we might begin this inner journey which leads to the mind, or land of Canaan, being transformed from a image of hell into an image of heaven.

The particular quality of food that needs to be prepared for this inner journey can only come into being as the *officers* or *scribes* or principles of Spiritual Christianity are able to pass through the *camp* or host. Now the Hebrew term '*camp*' or '*host*' is a term that refers to things of a military nature. In the inner world of the mind militant things have to do with the ideas that we defend our position with or the arguments which we use to attack what comes against us. So this *camp* or host as far as our internal man is concerned is made up of all the portions of the literal sense of the Word that contain truths that we have gathered up and are '*camped*' in our memory.

Now whilst the leadership of Moses, is represented the processes of spiritual instruction whereby we have the gathering of the host into the mind or memory, the state of mind represented by Joshua, is one of having this host organized into a force able to defeat what stands against what is good and true. This requires doctrine or teachings that enable us to see how the stories of the Word can be applied to this task, and these teachings are what we find in the doctrines for Spiritual Christianity and so they offer us the means for which our mind might be reformed and ordered.

The process of ordering our mind as far as our understanding of the Word is concerned requires the officers to "*pass through the camp.*" In other words, we need to bring our understanding of the doctrines represented by the *officers* when we read the Word, in an effort to understand its more

internal application for us. In its most simple internal application, the statement concerning the officers being commanded to pass through the camp is a command from the Lord as the Word to us, to use the principles of Spiritual Christianity to bring order to our understanding of the Word. And it is this inner or spiritual understanding of the Word that is able to sustain us and so serve as food for the journey into our own personal land of Canaan.

We can further confirm that this is indeed what is meant here for the word "*through*" in the phrase "*pass through the camp*" means '*the centre*' or '*the inward part*' and is often used in the Word to refer to the inner faculty of a persons thoughts and affections (see Psalm 39:3; Psalm 55:4). It is also the same word used when the Lord promised to place His law in the inward parts of His people (Jeremiah 31:33; also Ezekiel 11:19; 36:26).

Behold, the days come, says Jehovah, that I will cut a new covenant with the house of Israel and with the house of Judah, not according to the covenant that I cut with their fathers in the day I took them by the hand to bring them out of the land of Egypt (which covenant of Mine they broke, although I was a husband to them, says Jehovah). But this shall be the covenant that I will cut with the house of Israel: After those days, declares Jehovah, I will put My Law in their inward parts, and I will write it on their hearts; and I will be their God, and they shall be My people. (Jeremiah 31:31-33)

While it is the Lord who implants the law into our inner man, it is not done without our co-operation. The Lord writes His laws on our inward being as we use the Word, or Joshua and the *officers* or doctrines, to transform our understanding of the literal stories of the Text, represented by the *people*, into a form that can support our inner spiritual growth and development and so serve as *food* for our minds. It is this that leads to the development of a state of mind that enables the crossing of the Jordan and entry into the land.

So the question now is what does the Jordan spiritually represent? Last time we saw that the River Jordan forms a border between what stands outside the land of Canaan and what lies within it. In general we can say that the land of Canaan represents that part of the human mind that is largely concerned with internal things of the Church, or those things of the Church that belong to the internal man. This being the case then we can see that the lands mentioned in the Word which fall outside of its borders, particularly where they hold some sort of connection with the people of Israel, must represent the things of the Church that are more external in nature, and so belong to the external man. Now by the things of the Church we don't mean those things belonging to any external organisation, rather we mean those things to do with our understanding of the Word. The Word itself is what makes up the things of the Church, and so we find the teaching in the doctrines for Spiritual Christianity that a Church is only a Church in accordance with its understanding of the Word.

The Word has an external and an internal aspect to it. The external aspect, which is its body, is accommodated to the natural understanding of people and is what we call its literal sense. The internal aspect, its spirit or soul, lies within the external and we call this its spiritual sense. To prepare food for

the crossing of the Jordan is to make the necessary preparations that can support us to move beyond the fallacies of our senses or the surface meaning that arises from reading the Word literally. To do this we need to know that this deeper meaning exists, for without knowing this we won't seek to find it. We also won't seek it if we can't see why acquiring this deeper understanding of things is important. This is where the understanding provided in the doctrines for Spiritual Christianity is vital; for these give us the ability to see that there is a deeper meaning in the Scriptures and the purpose for which it is given.

So in preparation for this crossing over into the more interior things of life we need to motivate ourselves to ...

1. Read the Word
2. Learn about the principles of Spiritual Christianity
3. Use these principles to build our understanding of the Word's application to the life of our minds
4. Make an effort to use this understanding in working with the Lord to have the evils and falsities we recognise in our life removed.

If we do this, if we give spiritual things a priority in our lives, then the internal things of heaven will begin to appear more fully present in our consciousness and impact on our states of life in a real way for the good of all. This is because the internal things of heaven can only become more conscious to us as those things in our external man that are opposed to heaven are removed. The key then, to understanding the inner meaning of the Scriptures, is to work on oneself to have these things removed. We may know the Word, we may know the principles of Spiritual Christianity, but unless we use them and apply them to our life, then these don't help us. For it is in our willingness to work with them that they come together as a fighting force ready to defend what is of heaven within us. That first force of real inner change is described here as the Reubenites, the Gadites and the half tribe of Manasseh, things we will consider in more detail next time.

03. Bringing Reuben, Gad And Manasseh To The Fight (1:12-18)

And Joshua spoke to the Reubenites, and to the Gadites, and to the half tribe of Manasseh, saying, Remember the word which Moses the servant of Jehovah commanded you, saying, Jehovah your God has given you rest, and He has given to you this land. Your wives, your little ones, and your livestock shall remain in the land which Moses has given to you beyond the Jordan. But you shall cross over armed before your brothers, all the mighty warriors, and shall help them, until Jehovah has given rest to your brothers, as well as to you, and they, even they have possessed the land which Jehovah your God is giving to them. Then you may return to the land of your possession, and may possess it, which Moses the servant of Jehovah has given to you beyond the Jordan toward the rising of the sun. And they answered Joshua, saying, We will do all that you command us; and we will go everywhere you shall send us. According to all we heard from Moses, so we will listen to you. Surely Jehovah your God is with you, as He has been with Moses. Whoever rebels against your mouth, and will not listen to your commands in all that you say to him, he shall die. Only, be strong and brave. (Joshua 1:12-18)

(see also Numbers 32:16-25)

In general the twelve tribes meant everything constituting the doctrine of truth and good, that is, of faith and love; for these -- that is to say, truth and good, or faith and love -- constitute the Lord's kingdom, since what are essentially matters of truth or faith constitute the whole of thought there, and what are essentially matters of good or love constitute the whole of affection. And because the Jewish Church was established so as to represent the Lord's kingdom, the divisions of that people into twelve tribes therefore meant those things of His kingdom. This is an arcanum which has not previously been disclosed.

[2] Twelve means all things in general, as shown already in 577, 2089, 2129, 2130 (end), 3272, while 'tribes' means matters of truth and good, or of faith and love, so that 'the twelve tribes' means all of these.

(Arcana Coelestia 3858)

Last time in our look at the book of Joshua we discussed the need to make preparations in readiness to enter the land and of what this means for us so that we can be made ready for our entry into a greater sense of the spiritual dimension to our life. We saw this in the idea expressed in the story as a command that the children of Israel *prepare food*. Today we will be looking at another aspect of

preparation mentioned here which involves three tribes who have already been allocated their portion of land on the eastern side, or the side that stands outside that border of the Jordan River. These tribes are the Reubenites, the Gadites and the half tribe of Manasseh.

The first thing we need to establish in regard to the details being expressed here has to do with what the tribes of Israel represent in us. What we know is that people of Israel were divided into twelve tribes, with each tribe being descended from one of the sons of Jacob, who if you recall underwent a change of name and became Israel.

Everything in the Word in its deeper meaning relates to those things that belong to the process of mental development which are associated with peoples' spiritual awareness. In the Old Testament the universal principles, processes and issues of spiritual development are illustrated and represented in the lives of the various characters and peoples we find there. Jacob's life represents a state of mind that is experienced as we struggle to make spiritual realities more real in our daily life.

He represents a stage of spiritual life when we are very much reliant on our own efforts to take hold of spiritual things and make them our own. This is one aspect of the meaning of his name, for Jacob means "*supplanter*". This is because the stage of spiritual development that he represents is one where spiritual things are more something of the head than the life. Our relationship to them is more one of the intellect than of the heart, or if you like, there is an emphasis on ideas and concepts of truth, rather than the good that comes from applying these to our life. In this phase of development, truth can be said to have supplanted good, because a person's interest and focus is on ideas that may or may not have an obvious practical application. It is a necessary phase however as knowledge of spiritual things must first be acquired in order for there to be something within us that the Lord can use to motivate us to move from that knowledge to a focus on *how* that knowledge can be used for the benefit of others.

The growth of ideas and concepts about spiritual things, represented by the Jacob phase of our life, leads to their reworking in our minds as we think about them and draw new connections and insights. New ways of seeing things that relate to the development of our spiritual awareness are born and this is represented in the Word by the birth of sons. So the sons of Jacob represent all the various arrangements of affections and ideas about spiritual life which take form or are generated or born in people's minds as they look to develop a fuller sense of spirituality in their life.

What you find if you look at the story of Jacob's life is that his offspring were born to a number of different women, four to be exact. Without going into too much detail now, we should note that where Jacob represents a particular stage of a persons developing spiritual consciousness, the women to which he was joined and bore him offspring represent the various affections that are active in the process of our spiritual development. We all have an internal and external part to our minds, and these are separate and independent, and so form two distinct levels of being. We call these the external or natural man and the internal or spiritual man. These aspects of our minds each have their own will and understanding with their particular quality of affections and thoughts. The affections of the external mind give rise to the desires and pleasures which form the motivation that we need to attend to the things of a more external nature, particularly those which are focused on supporting the internal dimension of our spiritual life.

For example, an interest in reading spiritual material such as is found in the Bible and the doctrines

for Spiritual Christianity, or other books, being motivated to listen to lectures or sermons, or going to seminars and workshops, as well as attending church—all belong to those affections for spiritual things that are found in the external man or mind. The affections belonging to the internal man/mind take their form in our experience as a motivation to take the things that our external man has acquired and apply these to the activity of our mind, to our thoughts and affections, so that we can be more effective in expressing the Lord's love and wisdom, and thus as be more effective vessels of use to others.

These two different quality of affections, belonging to the internal and external aspect of our minds, are represented in the story of Jacob's life as his two wives, Leah and Rachel. Jacob was married to Leah first and then to Rachel. Now, the general principle is that we begin in external things and move towards internal things and we see this principle reflected here in the fact that Leah, whom Jacob married first, represents an external affection for truth and Rachel his second wife, represents an internal affection for truth. So, it was these two women along with their hand maidens that bore Jacob his sons.

It's necessary for us to have this background because it gives us a context for understanding the spiritual representation of the various tribes of Israel in us as we move through the book of Joshua. Those tribes born to Jacob through Leah and her handmaid or slave girl represent those things to do with our spiritual development which belong to the external aspects of spiritual life, while those born of Rachel and her handmaid represent what belongs to the more internal aspects of our spiritual life.

So we now come back to the book of Joshua and can begin to unfold what is involved as regards our preparation for the spiritual work as represented by the sons of Israel preparing to enter the land of Canaan. The Reubenites were descendants of Jacob's first born son by Leah, who was named Reuben. The Gadites were descendants of Gad, who was born to Leah's handmaid, Zilpah. Manasseh on the other hand was actually Jacob's grandson being the son of Joseph who was one of Jacob's sons by Rachel.

The land that these particular tribes received was requested and given to them when Moses was Israel's leader on the condition that they would fight along with the other tribes to rid the land of their enemies. The lands given to the Reubenites, the Gadites and to the half tribe of Manasseh were on the other side of the Jordan, with the Jordan forming a boundary between the inheritance of these three tribes and the rest. Now, because these tribes were located beyond or east of the Jordan they represent elements of the spiritual life that belong to the external man. We can see this from the following quote from the work the Apocalypse Explained 440 where it says that ...

The land beyond or without Jordan represented and signified the [external church], which is with [men] in the [natural man];
but the land on this side, or within Jordan, represented and signified the [internal church], which is with [men] in the [spiritual man].
Apocalypse Explained 440[7]

"The land beyond, or without the Jordan, represented and signified the [*external things of spiritual life*] with [*people*] in the [*natural _mind*];

but the land on this side, or within the Jordan, represented and signified the [*internal things belonging to spiritual life*] with [*people*] in the [*spiritual mind*]."

So we see that these three tribes had in effect been established in their lands under Moses. The establishment of these tribes in their lands highlights the principle that the external things of spiritual life that belong to the external or natural man must become established in our life first, before we can enter into a deeper work of inner repentance. Reuben is mentioned first, because by Reuben is meant the first stages in the development of our understanding of spiritual ideas or concepts which are largely related to the literal sense of the Word. Reuben then is connected to our acceptance of the basic foundational truths of the Word.

That Reuben represents this elementary understanding of spiritual ideas or concepts becomes very clear from the meaning of his name. Reuben literally means "*see a son!*". Both the word "*see*" and "*son*", spiritually relate to the things of the understanding. To "*see*" is the same as to understand, and "*son*" is used throughout the Word to signify truths. From this we see that Reuben has to do with our understanding of truths, and because his inheritance lies beyond Jordan, it is an external understanding built upon natural truths of the Word that are understood more in terms of the meaning present in its literal sense.

The Gadites, because they are mentioned second, represent what should follow on from this natural understanding of spiritual things. There are three things that make up the life of external man, the first has to do with intellectual things, the second has to do with the things related to the affections, and the third is when these things are exhibited in the actions that give them expression and life. So where *Reuben* represents what belongs to the intellectual side of the spiritual life in the natural man, *Gad*, or the *Gadites* here represent what is built up in a person's response in obedience to their understanding of truth, particularly when it feels difficult to stay motivated in spiritual life, and we have to compel ourselves as a matter of obedience to work. As we struggle and work from truths so *Gad* is born ...

...by Gad [is] described the good of life [that comes from living] according to truths from the Word
(Apocalypse Explained 435)

And so now what follows on from Gad is Manasseh. As we live in obedience to our understanding of the Word which we have developed, a real love and delight for the things of the Word flows into the natural man/mind from the spiritual man/mind. You would have noticed that Manasseh is referred to as a half tribe. This is because the inheritance granted to the tribe of Manasseh included an allotment of land on both sides of the Jordan, leading to half of the tribe existing within the Jordan and another half without. The placement of this tribe's lands either side of the Jordan is how the Word represents the link between the spiritual and natural man represented by *Manasseh*. Of Manasseh the Apocalypse Explained 440 says that ...

Manasseh represented ... good from a spiritual source in the natural man, therefore an inheritance was given to that tribe beyond or without the Jordan, and also on this side, or within the Jordan; to half of the tribe, beyond or without the Jordan, and to the

other half, on this side, or within the Jordan
(Apocalypse Explained 440)

Manasseh, however, at this stage of the story is only found to be established in that area of the land that represents the external mind. From this, we are to understand that Manasseh represents the first development of a new will which is of a higher quality for spiritual things , and so we read that ...

Manasseh means ... the delight of doing good and learning truth
(Apocalypse Explained 440)

So when we move from our understanding of the Word (*Reuben*) affirming its truths through our response (*Gad*), we will begin to see the development of a new quality of affection for the things of the Lord and heaven (*Manasseh*).

The lesson of these three tribes is that we can never rest on just the external elements of spiritual life. Knowledge of the Word is given to serve heavenly uses and those uses belong primarily to the things of the internal man. There is always the temptation of settling down into our acquired knowledge of the Word and understanding of the spiritual principles found in the doctrines for Spiritual Christianity. There is a temptation off merely being content with the externals of a religious or spiritual life, and leaving off using what we have from the Lord to engage in the fight of having that which is opposed to the heavenly life within our minds removed. Here we see that *Reuben*, *Gad* and *Manasseh* in us has to be brought to the fight so that the land that is our life might be free of every selfish pattern of feeling, thought, and behavior that exalts itself against the Lord.